

Expert Session Summary

Session conducted by Dr. Mohammed Sadik

MANO 2026 – Kerala's First Psychology Students' Conclave

Quick Brief Summary

Dr. Muhammed Sadique clarifies that continuous training, supervision, and self-therapy are essential for psychologists to bridge the gap between academic studies and the practical professional field. A psychologist truly becomes a professional only when they work by understanding the cultural background and personality of clients, beyond the theories in books.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

This lecture was delivered by Dr. Mohammed Sadique, a clinical psychologist and former assistant professor based in Kochi. He spoke on the topic, "The Gap Between What You Studied and What You'll Actually Do." He explains that the transition from student life to professional life is a 'transitional phase' and discusses how to overcome the challenges faced during this period.

Main Theme: The Gap Between Academic Psychology and Practical Training

This lecture addresses the significant difference between the psychological theories learned in books and the real-world situations encountered in clinical practice. The central theme is how to develop the practical skills necessary not just to possess knowledge as a psychologist, but to understand clients, behave appropriately according to the context, and protect one's own mental health.

Key Areas Explored

The Relationship Between Psychologist and Client

Individuals who come to a psychologist trust in their qualifications and degrees. Therefore, he reminds professionals to set aside doubts about their identity as a psychologist and be ready to accept that responsibility. Diagnosis should not be based on textbook definitions, but by understanding each individual's cultural background. For example, drinking alcohol during a

specific celebration might be normal in one culture, while it could be considered abnormal on another day. Recognizing this difference is a hallmark of a good psychologist.

Assessment and Documentation

Psychological tests are not merely for records; they are tools to understand the depth of a client's problems. A psychologist must be careful to identify discrepancies between projective tests and clinical interviews. Furthermore, he emphasizes the importance of maintaining accurate documentation for medico-legal purposes. Much like the methods from the time of Sigmund Freud, preparing precise notes after every session is essential for the safety of both the therapist and the client.

Theory and Practice: Transference and Counter-transference

He analyzes the key psychoanalytic concepts of transference and counter-transference. The emotions a therapist feels toward a client (counter-transference) are not wrong; rather, they should be analyzed and used constructively in therapy. He suggests using concepts like Object Relations Theory to understand a client's childhood experiences and relationships. Additionally, he reminds us that undergoing supervision and personal therapy is essential for the growth of a professional psychologist.

Key Insights: Guidelines for Professional Growth

1. Continuous Learning: Keep knowledge updated according to new changes in psychology.
2. Networking: Building connections with other experts in the field helps with referrals and career growth.
3. Supervision: Seeking supervision under experienced mentors helps remove obstacles in therapy.
4. Self-Care: Engage in personal therapy to maintain your own mental health.

Conclusion: A Call to Practicality

Dr. Sadique asserts that while the gap between academic study and practical life exists, it is something that can be bridged. He calls on students to believe in their own abilities as psychologists and to become better professionals through continuous training and supervision. He concludes the lecture with the optimistic belief that by helping clients, one can make a significant contribution to society.

The gap between academic studies and practical life

The transition from the dependent state during studies to the independent state in professional life is a transitional phase. Beyond textbook theories, patients must be treated by understanding them personally in clinical situations.

Assessment and clinical approach

Instead of looking only at symptoms, the patient's social and cultural backgrounds should also be considered. Psychological tests are not just for records, but for accurate diagnosis and treatment plans.

Boundaries and documentation

Professional boundaries are essential for the safety of both the therapist and the client. It is a psychologist's responsibility to maintain accurate documentation of every session for medico-legal purposes and safety.

Continuous growth and supervision

To grow as a psychologist, it is essential to undergo supervision and engage in personal therapy. Only by ensuring one's own mental health can one help others.